

Chapter 4

The Turkish Invasion and the Establishment of the Delhi Sultanate

History — Chapter Notes

Learning Outcomes

By the end of this chapter, the learner will be able to:

- discuss the emergence of Delhi as a seat of power
- name the five dynasties that ruled Delhi
- analyse the influence and impact of notable rulers on the Sultanate
- evaluate the key features of the Mamluk dynasty

Warm Up!

What happened to the great Arab empire of the Abbasid Caliphate as the power of the Caliphs declined in the 8th and 9th centuries CE?

1. The Turks

The cultural vitality and brilliance of the Abbasid Caliphate in the 8th and 9th centuries CE was deeply absorbed in mutual rivalries. This power was followed by a decline in its political power by the end of the 9th century CE. The once-mighty Abbasid empire disintegrated into a number of independent states ruled by the Turks — who had earlier served in the armies of the Caliphs. Two important states established by the Turks were **Ghazni** and **Ghor**.

2. Mahmud of Ghazni

Sultan Mahmud of Ghazni was a powerful and ambitious ruler. He invaded India **17 times in the course of 25 years (1001–25 CE)**. He wanted to build a large and well-equipped army to expand his kingdom and also to protect it from his enemies in Central Asia. To fulfil his aims, he needed money — and the fabulous riches of the **temples of north India** attracted him.

At that time, north India was **divided**, and there was no unity among the ambitious Rajputs.

Important Raids (1001–25 CE)

War against Jaipal

Mahmud first defeated Jaipal, the Hindu ruler of Punjab, whose territory extended from the Punjab to present-day Afghanistan. Jaipal was forced to **pay tribute**. Unable to bear the humiliation of the defeat, Jaipal burnt himself to death.

War against Anandapal

Jaipal's son and successor Anandapal formed an **alliance** with the rulers of some Indian states to repulse Ghazni and protect their states and culture. Several important states of western and central India joined this alliance to meet the threat of a foreign invasion. Mahmud was, however, victorious, and the grave threat to the defence of India was crushed.

Somnath Temple

Hundreds of temples were plundered and destroyed, but Mahmud's most ambitious and profitable expedition was his attack on the **Somnath Temple** in Kathiawar. The Indians put up a stubborn resistance to save the magnificent temple — the richest and most sacred temple of the Hindus. After three days of fierce fighting, the entire defence force of about **50,000 soldiers lay dead**. The victorious Mahmud returned to his capital with immense treasures, including valuable works of art.

Mahmud drained away India's vast treasures and used them to finance further military campaigns in Central Asia. Sultan Mahmud transformed Ghazni into a magnificent capital city adorned with splendid mosques, libraries and a museum, glittering with sparkling pearls, rubies and diamonds.

Mahmud was known as the **idol breaker** and as a bandit operating on a grand scale in Indian history. However, the court of Ghazni was also a centre of art and learning, and he was a **patron of art and learning** who enjoyed the company of learned scholars and poets. Among the eminent scholars patronized by Mahmud were **Firdausi**, author of the great Persian epic *Shahnama*, and the mathematician and historian **Al Beruni**.

Mahmud's raids exposed the **weaknesses** of the northern states and paved the way for the **conquest of India**. The empire of Ghazni disintegrated rapidly after Mahmud's death, and for about 150 years India was free from foreign attacks.

Knowledge of India

The Rajput royal families linked their lineage either with the Suryavamsi (solar) or the Chandravamsi (lunar), the royal lineages of the Itihasa-purana tradition, or with the Agnikula (fire) lineage.

When Muhammad Ghori invaded India at the end of the 12th century CE, there were five major Rajput kingdoms in north India — the **Rathors** of Kanauj, the **Chauhans** of Delhi and Ajmer, the **Solankis** of Gujarat, the **Paramaras** of Malwa and the **Chandellas** of Bundelkhand.

3. Muhammad Ghori

Towards the end of the 12th century CE, a new kingdom based in Ghor arose in north-western Afghanistan (near Ghazni). Muhammad, the ruler of Ghor, decided to conquer and enrich his kingdom. He first brought the areas of Multan, Sind and Punjab under his control.

Important Battles

First Battle of Tarain

In 1191 CE, Ghori attacked Prithviraj Chauhan, the Rajput ruler of Delhi and Ajmer. Prithviraj organized a **confederacy of Rajput chiefs** to meet the challenge. Prithviraj Chauhan inflicted a crushing defeat on Ghori in the **First Battle of Tarain (1191 CE)**.

Second Battle of Tarain

Ghori returned the following year to avenge his defeat. In 1192 CE, the armies of the Rajputs and Ghori clashed again in the **Second Battle of Tarain**. This time Muhammad Ghori routed the Rajput army.

The **defeat** of Prithviraj in north India marked the end of Rajput rule in Delhi. The kingdom of Delhi passed into the hands of Muhammad Ghori. The throne of Delhi was then occupied by Qutbuddin Aibak. Two years after the Second Battle of Tarain, Muhammad Ghori attacked Kanauj and killed Jaichandra. He annexed the Indian territories.

Muhammad Ghori was not as great a military leader as Mahmud of Ghazni, nor did he patronize art and learning like him. Yet some historians consider him the **founder of the Turkish Muslim kingdom** in India, with its capital in Delhi.

Think and Answer

Why do you think Raja Jaichandra of Kanauj refused to help Prithviraj Chauhan during the Second Battle of Tarain?

4. The Mamluk Dynasty

Muhammad Ghori died in 1206 CE. He had no heirs, so his viceroys declared themselves independent in different parts of his empire.

Know Your Sources

This is a statue of Prithviraj, at Ajmer. Look at his posture, attire and weaponry. Discuss how these attributes might have influenced his leadership and military strategies.

The Delhi Sultanate

The period between **1206–1526 CE** is known as the period of the **Delhi Sultanate** because the rulers were known as *sultans* and they ruled from Delhi as their capital city.

HOTS

Do you think the history of India would have been different if Raja Jaichandra had helped Prithviraj Chauhan? Why?

5. Qutbuddin Aibak

Muhammad Ghori's most trusted general and former slave, Qutbuddin Aibak, was made governor of Delhi by Ghori. On Muhammad Ghori's death, Qutbuddin Aibak assumed control of Ghori's Indian possessions and declared himself the first **Sultan of Delhi**. He founded the **Delhi Sultanate**, so the dynasty is also referred to as the **Mamluk or Slave Dynasty**.

Qutbuddin ruled for about 4 years (1206–10 CE). According to court historians, he was a **just** ruler who looked after the welfare of his subjects. He broke several ancient temples to collect wealth and the material required to build mosques and other monuments. He was known as **Lakshbaksh**, or 'giver of lakhs', because of his generosity.

Qutbuddin built two mosques — the **Quwwat-ul-Islam** mosque at Delhi and another mosque at Ajmer — and started another monument at Delhi, the **Qutb Minar**, which was completed by his successor, Iltutmish. Qutbuddin died in **1210 CE** after falling from a horse.

6. Iltutmish

Though Qutbuddin was succeeded by his son, Qutbuddin's fall from the throne was accidental — he was soon replaced by **Iltutmish (1210–36 CE)**, his capable son-in-law and a capable ruler.

He first **consolidated** his position through shrewd and clever handling of all those who challenged his authority. Turkish nobles who had challenged his claim to the throne were suppressed, and the revolt of the Khilji governor of Bengal was crushed.

The power of his external rivals, the rulers of Ghazni and Multan, was destroyed. A new danger presented itself when the Mongol chief, **Chengiz Khan**, reached the borders of India in pursuit of the Shah of Khwarezm (present-day Iran), who had fled towards India in search of shelter. Iltutmish politely refused to give him shelter, and by doing so, saved India from the threat of a Mongol invasion.

After getting rid of his external enemies, Iltutmish set about consolidating and stabilizing his kingdom. Iltutmish is regarded as the **true founder** of the Delhi Sultanate; he transformed the loosely-knit territories in India into a strong, well-defined, compact state.

Iltutmish completed the Qutb Minar and also built his own tomb in Delhi. Learned scholars from various parts of Asia found refuge in his court. He was the first to mint gold and silver coins, and organized the revenue departments of the Sultanate. The Sultanate was divided into several provinces called **iqtas**. Each iqta was administered by an officer or noble called the **iqtdar**.

Did You Know?

The Caliph of Baghdad recognized Iltutmish as the sovereign of India.

7. Razia Sultan

Itutmish nominated his daughter **Razia** as his successor. His nobles did not like the idea of being ruled by a woman. So Razia had to prove her qualities of a great monarch. She **dressed like a man**, transacted business in the open durbar, and rode horses and led the armies into battle. The welfare of her subjects was her primary duty.

Later, most of Mahmud's attacks were directed towards the temple towns of north India. A temple at Somnath was among the most famous.

Some provincial governors rose in **revolt** against her. Razia tried to crush the revolt but was defeated and imprisoned. She won over her captor, **Altunia**, by marrying him, and tried to recover her throne, but her attempt failed — both she and Altunia were killed in 1240 CE.

Discuss

Who, according to you, was the real founder of the Delhi Sultanate — Qutbuddin Aibak or Itutmish? Give reasons for your answer.

Sustainable Development Goals — Goal 5: Gender Equality

Gender equality and empowering all women and girls is an important step towards removing inequalities. Razia Sultan was a capable and just ruler, but she was eventually overthrown because she was a woman ruler. How has the scenario changed in the present time?

After Itutmish's death, internal strife began among the nobles. Their leader of the group of nobles, the powerful **Chalisa**, placed **Nasiruddin Mahmud**, the youngest son of Itutmish, on the throne. He was a weak and inexperienced person, and **Ghiyasuddin Balban**, began to manage the affairs of the state.

8. Ghiyasuddin Balban

Balban died in **1266 CE**, and Sultan Ghiyasuddin Balban ascended the throne of Delhi and ruled for nearly **20 years (1266–86 CE)**. He believed in the theory of **Divine Kingship**, i.e. the king was God's representative on earth.

These peaceful and stable conditions were favourable for the development of agriculture, trade and commerce, and led to the economic prosperity of the kingdom.

Balban mercilessly suppressed the ambitious Turkish nobles. Tughril Khan, his governor of Bengal, revolted against the sultan; Balban personally marched against him and had him killed.

It is said that Balban never smiled or joked in his court, and no one was allowed to laugh or joke in his presence. The nobles had to kneel and touch the ground with their forehead to show their respect. Balban made the monarchy **absolute** and **all-powerful**. He **reorganized** the army, strengthened both the cavalry and infantry, and erected forts at strategic places.

He set up an elaborate **spy system**. A tribe that robbed travellers and created serious law and order problems was ruthlessly suppressed. He appointed his own sons as governors of frontier provinces. New forts were built and old ones repaired to strengthen his defences against a Mongol invasion. He was sure the Mongols would take advantage of his absence and invade his kingdom, so he never left his capital, though he had a well-equipped army always ready in a state of readiness.

Balban died in **1286 CE**. His four successors were weak and incompetent. Four years after his death, the Delhi Sultanate passed into the hands of the **Khilji** dynasty.

Values and Life Skills

Both men and women should be given equal opportunities to learn and grow. There should be no gender bias. Razia Sultan had all the qualities of a great monarch, but the nobles did not like the idea of being ruled by a woman, and she was eventually overthrown. If you were a noble in the court of Razia Sultan, what would you have done?

Security and stability replaced lawlessness and disorder.

9. Timeline

Period	Event
c. 1000 CE	Mahmud of Ghazni invaded India
1191 CE	First Battle of Tarain
1192 CE	Second Battle of Tarain
1206–10 CE	Reign of Qutbuddin Aibak
1210–36 CE	Reign of Iltutmish
1236–40 CE	Reign of Razia Sultan
1266–86 CE	Reign of Ghiyasuddin Balban

10. Important Words

Sultans — The rulers of Delhi, their capital city.

Iqtas — The provinces into which the Delhi Sultanate was usually divided during Iltutmish's reign. Each was administered by an officer or noble called the iqtadar.

Muezzin — A man who calls Muslims to prayer, usually from the tower of a mosque.

Divine Kingship — The belief that the king is a representative of God on earth.

Lakhs — 'Giver of lakhs'; Qutbuddin Aibak was given this name because of his generosity.

Shahnama — Written by the Persian poet Firdausi; it is the biography of Sultan Mahmud of Ghazni.

Biography — Chengiz Khan

Chengiz Khan (born 1162 CE) was the founder and first khan of the Mongol empire. He ruled from 1206 CE until his death in 1227 CE. Later, it became the largest contiguous empire in history. He spent most of his life uniting the Mongol tribes and conquering large parts of China and Central Asia. He is also regarded as the founding father of the nation of Mongolia.

11. Exercises

A. Fill in the Blanks

1. Mahmud of Ghazni invaded India _____ times in the course of _____ years.
2. Mahmud's raids exposed the _____ of the northern states and paved the way for the _____ of India.
3. Qutbuddin Aibak took control of Muhammad Ghori's _____ possessions and laid the foundation of the _____.
4. Iltutmish defeated the Rajput rulers of _____ and brought the whole of northern India up to the river _____ under his control.
5. The _____ recognized Iltutmish as the sovereign of India.

B. Match the Following

A	B
1. Mahmud of Ghazni	(a) general of Ghori
2. Qutbuddin Aibak	(b) Prithviraj defeated Muhammad Ghori
3. Second Battle of Tarain	(c) patron of art and learning
4. Muhammad bin Bakhtiar Khilji	(d) viceroy of Ghori
5. Muhammad Ghori	(e) Prithviraj was defeated by Muhammad Ghori

C. Choose the Correct Answer

1. Mahmud of Ghazni was interested in territorial expansion in South Asia / Central Asia / West Asia.
2. Firdausi was a great mathematician / historian / poet.
3. Nasiruddin Mahmud was a weak and inexperienced ruler, and the affairs of the state during his reign were managed by Balban / Iltutmish / Razia Sultan on his behalf.
4. Balban / Iltutmish / Razia Sultan never smiled or allowed others to laugh in his court.
5. Iltutmish / Qutbuddin Aibak / Balban is considered the true founder of the Delhi Sultanate.

D. True or False (rewrite the false statements correctly)

1. The kingdoms of Ghazni and Ghor were established by the Abbasids.
2. Razia Sultan made the monarchy weak and dependent on the nobles.
3. Balban failed to crush the power of the nobles.
4. Iltutmish/Qutbuddin Aibak's reign, north India was divided and there was no unity among the rulers.

5. Balban never smiled or allowed others to laugh in his court.

E. My Mixed Bag — Name the Following

- (a). He is the founder of the Slave (Mamluk) Dynasty.
- (b). He made the monarchy all-powerful and absolute.
- (c). He believed in the theory of Divine Kingship.
- (d). He never left his capital to conquer new territories.

F. Answer in One or Two Sentences

1. What happened to the great Abbasid Caliphate by the 9th century CE?
2. Name the author of the epic Shahnama.
3. Who did Muhammad Ghori appoint as his viceroy in Delhi?
4. What is the significance of the Qutb Minar?
5. How did Muhammad Ghori's death lead to the emergence of the Delhi Sultanate?
6. How did Iltutmish save India from the threat of a Mongol invasion?
7. Mention two important contributions of Balban to the Delhi Sultanate.

G. Give Reasons for the Following

1. Why did Sultan Mahmud of Ghazni want to build a large and well-equipped army?
2. Why did Buddhism decline in India after the Turkish invasions?
3. Why did Iltutmish nominate his daughter Razia as his successor?
4. Why was Qutbuddin Aibak known as 'Lakhabaksh'?
5. Why did the Mongols not invade India during the reign of Iltutmish?

H. Answer Briefly

1. How did Sultan Mahmud of Ghazni transform his capital, Ghazni? How do we know he was a patron of art and learning?
2. Discuss the important developments that took place during the reign of Razia Sultan.
3. With reference to (a) the Mongols, explain how Balban maintained security and stability in his kingdom.
4. Why did Buddhism decline in India during the Turkish invasion?
5. Why was Iltutmish nominated as his successor by Qutbuddin Aibak?

I. Source-Based Questions — Picture Study

This is a portrait of a Turkish invader who was involved in the Battles of Tarain.

1. Identify the person in the picture. Why did he invade India?
2. The Battles of Tarain laid the foundation of Turkish rule in north India. Do you agree? Why?
3. Explain the causes of the success of the Turkish invaders against the Rajputs.

12. Do and Learn

A. Use Your Imagination

1. Imagine you are Prithviraj Chauhan, the leader of the Rajput confederacy, preparing to meet the challenge of an attack by Muhammad Ghori. Give an account of the usual day-to-day proceedings in the royal court. The narration may be supplemented with an enactment of the scenes by the students.
2. Imagine you are a royal official in Ghiyasuddin Balban's court. Prepare and deliver a speech to the combined armies that will inspire and motivate the soldiers to face the challenge with confidence and courage.

B. Project Work

1. Collect information on the great Persian poet, Firdausi, and the great historian, Al Beruni. Find some interesting anecdotes about their achievements and contributions.
2. Prepare a picture album of the rulers of the Mamluk dynasty. Present either a PowerPoint presentation or a file project on their achievements.
3. Make an outline map of the Indian subcontinent, mark and label (a) the extent of the empire of Mahmud of Ghazni and (b) the areas overrun by him.

Map Work

1. On an outline map of the Indian Subcontinent, mark and label (a) the extent of the empire of Mahmud of Ghazni and (b) the areas overrun by him.

13. Self-Assessment

Learning Outcomes	I need help	I have a basic understanding	My work consistently meets expectations	I have deeper understanding
I can discuss the emergence of Delhi as a seat of power.				
I can name the five dynasties that ruled Delhi.				
I can analyse the influence and impact of notable rulers on the Sultanate.				
I can evaluate the key features of the Mamluk dynasty.				

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